

What value does ECDC's RespiCast have — and could it have?

Evidence from the survey of national focal points · a supplement to the summary

INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS · DE-IDENTIFIED ECDC RESPICOMPASS-2024 NFP SURVEY · N = 19 COUNTRIES

In 2024, ECDC surveyed the **National Focal Points (NFPs)** for respiratory viruses — the designated national contacts at each country's public-health institute. **Nineteen countries replied**, one collective answer each. The survey asked how much modelling each institute can do itself, how **aware** they are of ECDC's modelling products, which national decisions those products might inform, and which outputs they would prefer. This supplement gathers the answers that bear on one question: what value does ECDC's weekly short-term forecasting service, **RespiCast**, have today — and what value could it have? Every figure is generated directly from the survey.

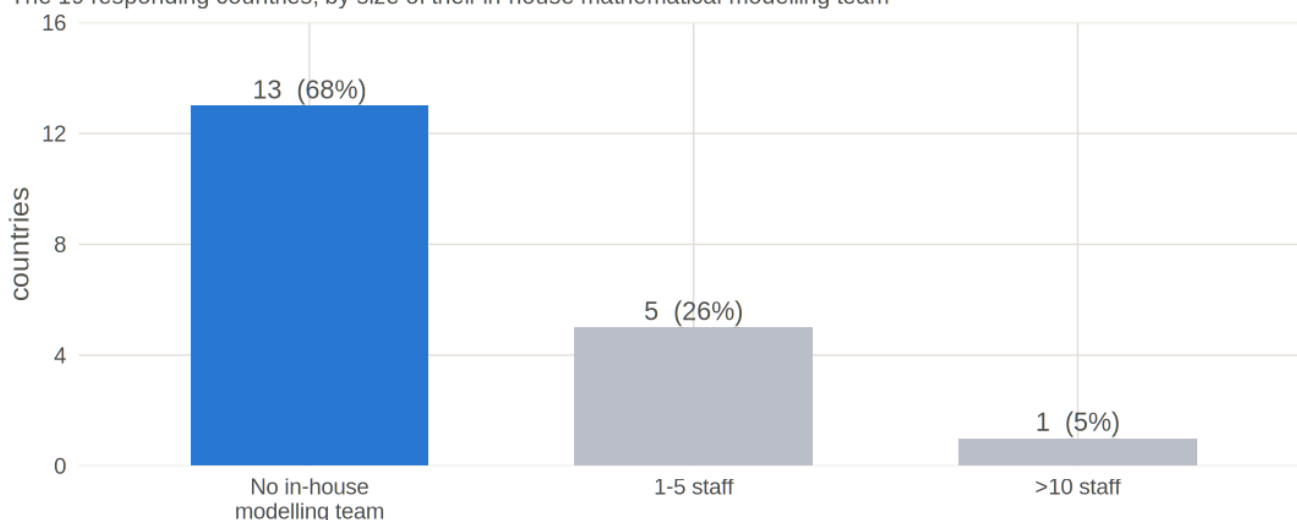
In one line. RespiCast is the ECDC forecast that national institutes most want, and for most countries it is the **only** forecast they have — yet its realised value is still modest and held back on the **demand side** (awareness, interpretability, and a route into decisions), not by any shortage of forecasts.

1 The need — most countries cannot forecast for themselves

For most member states, an external forecast is the **only** forecast. **13 of the 19 institutes (68%)** have no in-house mathematical modeller at all, and only one has a team larger than five. So for two-thirds of responding countries RespiCast is not a second opinion — it is their forecasting capability. This is the single biggest reason the service has value at all.

Most national institutes cannot forecast in-house

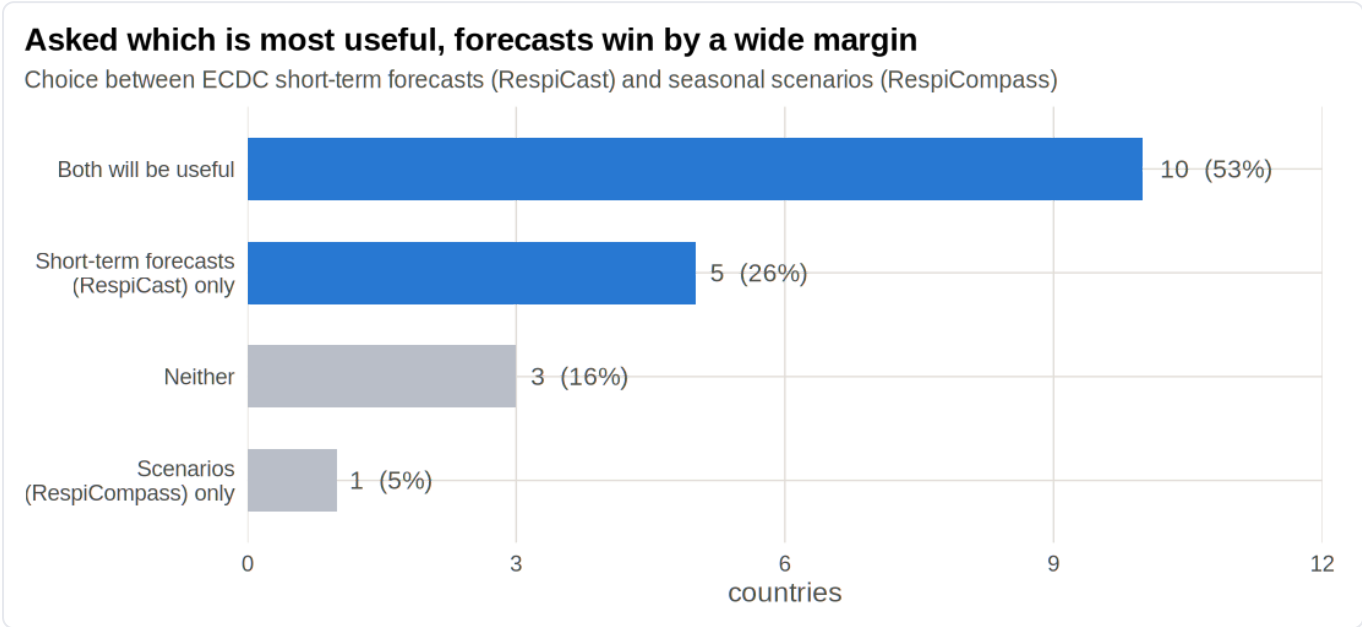
The 19 responding countries, by size of their in-house mathematical-modelling team



Survey question on in-house modelling staff · 19 countries

2 The preference — forecasts are wanted more than scenarios

Asked which ECDC product will be most useful, countries clearly favour forecasts over scenarios. **Ten of 19 (53%)** expect both to be useful; among those who picked just one, **RespiCast (forecasts) was chosen five times to RespiCompass's (scenarios) one** — a 5:1 margin. Only 3 (16%) expected neither to help. In the open comments, NFPs explain why: short-term forecasts are seen as **more reliable and more actionable** than long-horizon (e.g. six-month) scenarios.

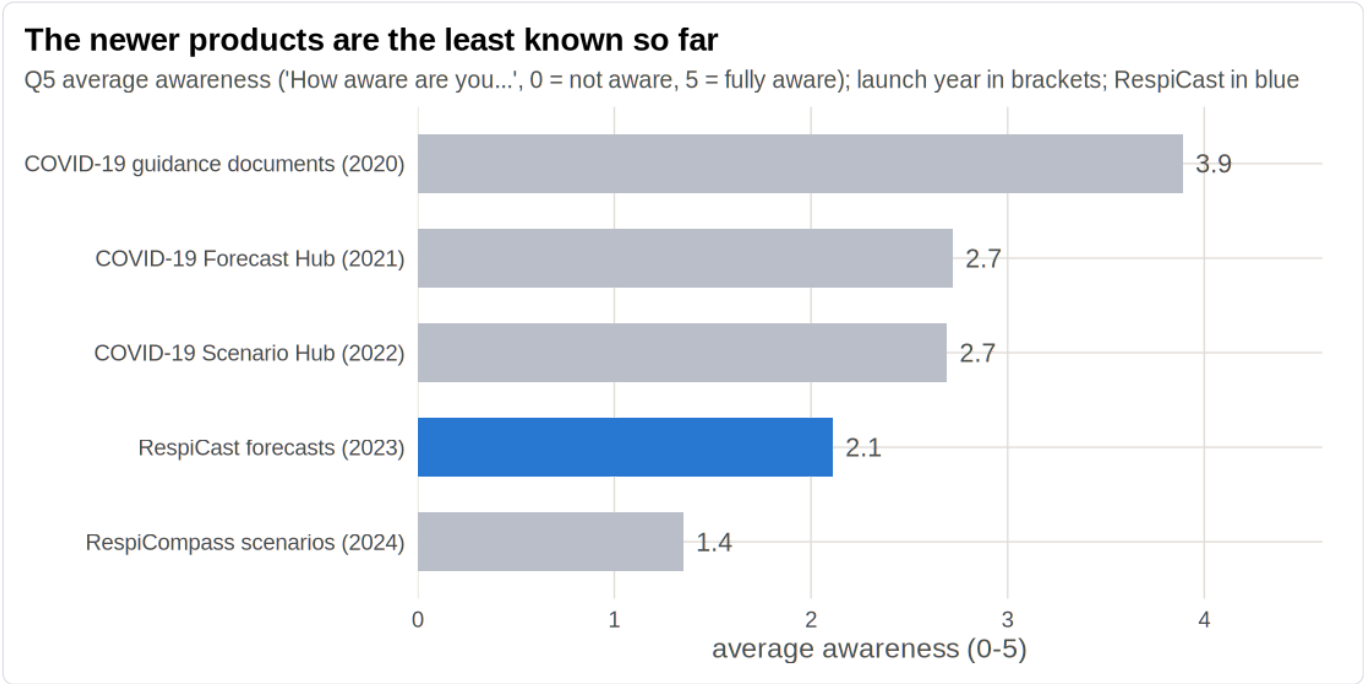


Survey question on the most valuable output · 19 countries

3 Current standing — still not widely known

The survey asked how **aware** each institute is of ECDC's modelling outputs (0 = not aware, 5 = fully aware) — this measures awareness, not use. Awareness of RespiCast averages **2.1** — below the older COVID-era products (2.7–3.9) and above only RespiCompass (1.4). This is largely a **recency** effect: awareness tracks how long an output has been in circulation, so the newest products are the least known, and about **one in six (17%)** NFPs were not yet aware of RespiCast at all. It is an awareness gap, not a verdict on value.

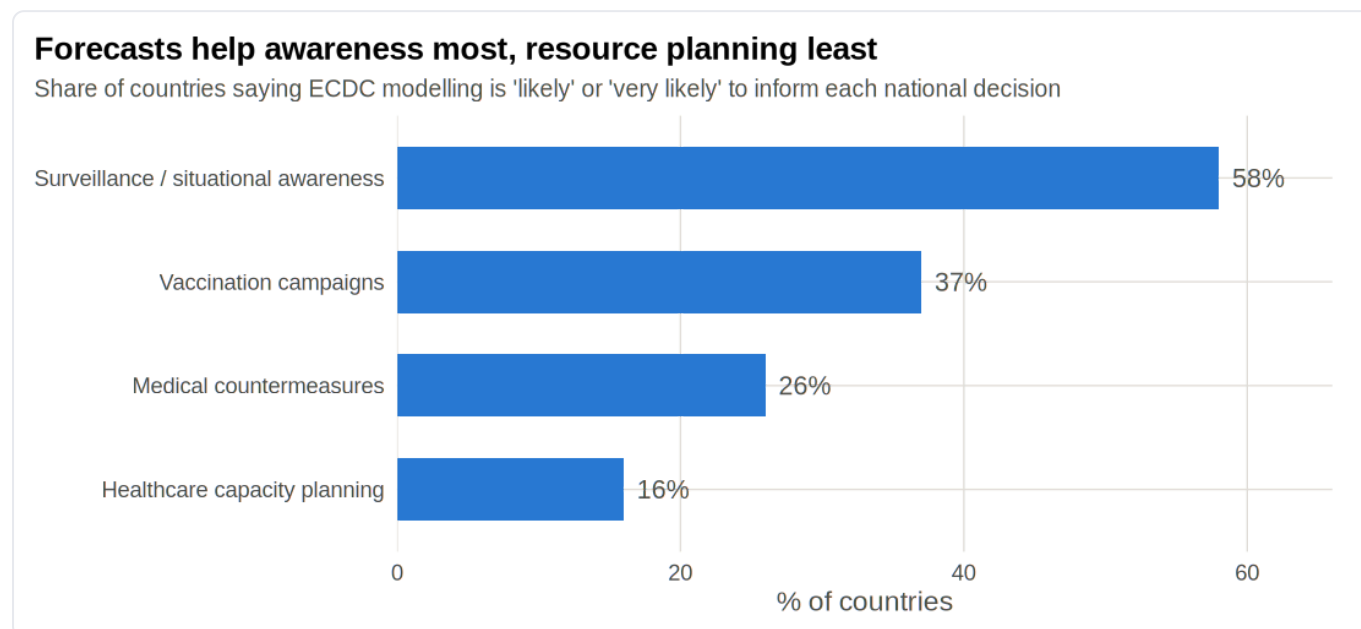
Tellingly, awareness is **no higher where a country has no team of its own** (about 2.1 either way), and **every institute entirely unaware** of RespiCast is one with no in-house team — so the awareness gap sits exactly where the need is greatest, and is cheap to close. Whether closing it converts into **use** the survey does not measure; the open comments are the only signal there.



Survey question on awareness of each ECDC modelling output ("How aware are you...", 0–5)

4 Where the value lands — awareness today, resources not yet

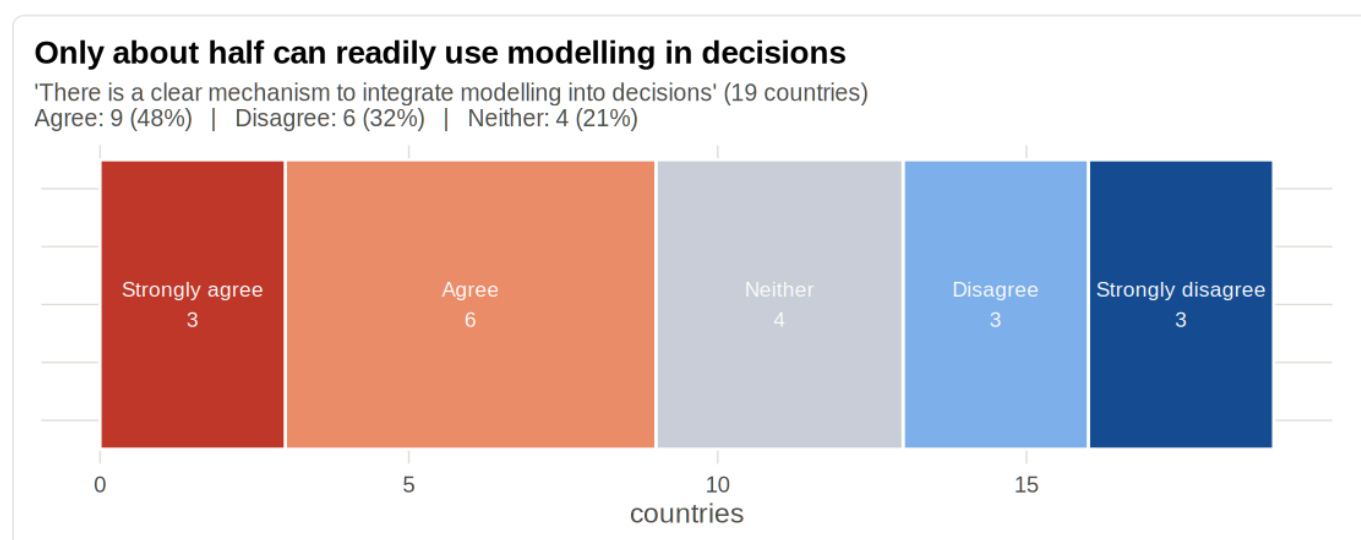
Where would forecasts actually feed decisions? Most often in **situational awareness**: 58% say ECDC modelling is likely to inform surveillance activities. Vaccination-campaign planning follows at 37%. The classic forecasting use case — **planning hospital and healthcare capacity** — is the **least** likely, at just 16%. Today's value is concentrated in knowing where a season stands, not yet in committing scarce resources — which points to where the next gains could come from.



Survey question on decisions ECDC modelling would inform · % 'likely / very likely'

5 The ceiling — a missing pathway into decisions

The main brake on value is not the forecast but the **pathway to use it**. Only **9 of 19 institutes (48%)** agree there is a clear, consistent mechanism to fold modelling into national public-health decisions; **6 (32%)** disagree. Even an accurate, timely forecast stalls if there is no route from the chart to the decision — so building that route is among the highest-leverage things ECDC and member states could do.



Survey question on a clear mechanism to integrate modelling into decisions · 19 countries

6 Value it has, and value it could have

VALUE RESPICAST HAS TODAY	LATENT VALUE IT COULD HAVE
The most-wanted ECDC forecast (chosen 5:1 over scenarios)	Reach the 68% of countries with no team of their own, who are currently no more aware than the rest
The only forecast most countries have	Become usable by the non-modellers who consume it — via plain-language outputs and short training
Trusted more than long-horizon scenarios	Earn decision-grade trust with a transparent skill / track-record (accuracy shown, not assumed)
Feeds situational awareness (surveillance, 58%)	Extend into higher-stakes planning — healthcare capacity is only 16% today
Delivered reliably (an ensemble almost every week)	Be wired into the decision — only 48% report a clear mechanism to use it, and into surveillance data (ERVISS)

The open comments point to the same levers, and add one more: a recurring ask for **ECDC to back, and help fund, national modelling capacity** — so that countries can absorb and act on forecasts in the first place.

7 How to read these numbers

Nineteen countries replied (of ~30 EU/EEA NFPs), so every share moves by about five points per country — read the figures as **direction and magnitude, not precise percentages**. The 0–5 scale measures **awareness** ("how aware are you..."), not use or a usefulness rating. "Which will be most useful" is a stated **expectation** — several respondents note they have not yet used the products. Newer products have had less time in circulation, which depresses their awareness scores. None of this measures forecast **accuracy**; it measures what national institutes say they need, value and use.

Source: de-identified ECDC RespiCompass-2024 NFP survey (data/survey_deidentified.xlsx). Figures generated from the survey by code/05_figures/fig_respicast_value.R. Companion interactive dashboard: claude.ai/code/artifact/83633670-7442-4950-b097-d6556709f5e9. An independent analysis — not an ECDC publication.